Ke Cheng HSU (Clio)
Department of Economics, The Hong Kong University of Science and Technology
Clear Water Bay, Kowloon, Hong Kong · +852 6840 9753
khsu@connect.ust.hk · cliohsu1997.github.io

7 November 2026

Faculty Search Committee
Department of Economics, National Taiwan University
No. 1, Sec. 4, Roosevelt Road
Taipei 106319, Taiwan

Dear Members of the Search Committee,

I am writing to apply for a faculty position at the assistant professor level or above in the Department of Economics at National Taiwan University. I am a Ph.D. candidate in Economics at the Hong Kong University of Science and Technology, expecting to graduate in June 2027, before the July 2027 degree requirement, and able to begin afterward. My fields are Empirical Industrial Organization and Digital Economics. I grew up in Taiwan and worked as a research assistant at National Taiwan University before my doctoral studies, and I can teach in both Chinese and English.

My job market paper, "Designing Return Policy in E-Commerce: A Trade-off between Purchase and Return Efficiency," studies whether a return policy encourages efficient returns and purchases. A stricter policy curbs inefficient returns after delivery, but the lower return rate makes a higher product price more attractive for the seller and can exclude efficient purchases. Using transaction data from a Taobao apparel retailer, I estimate a structural model of purchase, return, and whether to buy return-shipping insurance under monopoly pricing across six categories. Automatic coverage of return shipping performs better when the margin, net scrap value, and uncertainty are high, because it expands efficient purchases. Optional coverage performs better when those attributes are low, because it curbs excessive returns. A menu that pairs a discounted price with a medium restocking fee balances the two margins and performs better than both insurance policies for most categories.

A second working paper, "Product Design with Heterogeneous Search Costs" (with Pak Hung Au), studies how firms choose product design when consumers differ in search costs. Search costs shape which products consumers search. Consumers with low search costs seek niche products, and consumers with high search costs seek standardized products. A fall in search costs can raise prices when this shift in which product consumers search outweighs the effect that encourages more search. I also have two ongoing projects. With Kohei Kawaguchi and Kei Kawai, I use Japanese bookstore data to study how resale price maintenance encourages retailers to hold inventory in low-demand states. However, unsold copies cannot be cleared by cutting the price, so they are returned and discarded at an environmental cost. With Ce Bian and Liang Zhao, I build a theoretical model of pass-through when products can be returned, and show that a tax can lower the equilibrium price and raise welfare by reducing the return rate.

At HKUST I was a teaching assistant from 2020 to 2025 for undergraduate macroeconomics, the economics of uncertainty and information, and Ph.D. microeconomic theory, with an average evaluation of 4.72/5. In 2026 I designed and lectured the mathematics camp for the MSc in Economics, receiving 4.53/5. I am prepared to teach industrial organization, microeconomic theory, information economics, and econometrics from the undergraduate level through the graduate level.

I submit my CV, job market paper, the working paper named above, and my unofficial transcript. Pak Hung Au, Kohei Kawaguchi, and Kei Kawai will submit their letters through JOE. You can reach me at khsu@connect.ust.hk or +852 6840 9753.

Sincerely,

Ke Cheng HSU
Ph.D. Candidate, Department of Economics, HKUST